GRACE COMMUNITY CHURCH

Faith: 101 Bible Study

METHODISM : 101

PARTS 3 & 4: WHAT WE BELIEVE

How does grace change us?

Wednesday, November 11, 2026

7:00 PM ET · Zoom & Facebook Live

Rev. Dr. Arian B. Harris

OPENING PRAYER

God who loved us first, before we knew your name: meet us again tonight. Find us where we are, forgive what we bring, and grow us into people who love you and our neighbors with our whole hearts. In Jesus' name, Amen.

A

QUESTION A

OPENING · CHECK-IN · ★ CORE

Last time we tried three simple rules: do no harm, do good, stay in love with God. What happened when you tried one?

> *“Do not merely listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves. Do what it says.”*
>
> **James 1:22 (NIV)**

RECAP · PART 1

A MOVEMENT, NOT A NEW CHURCH

1729 · OXFORD

The “Holy Club.” Mocked as “Methodists” for their method; they kept the name.

1738 · LONDON

Aldersgate. John Wesley’s heart was “strangely warmed.”

1739 · BRISTOL

Field preaching. “No holiness but social holiness.”

1784 · BALTIMORE

The Methodist Episcopal Church is organized, with Black Methodists there from the start.

RECAP · PART 2

FOUR FAMILIES, ONE STORY

AME · 1816

Philadelphia. Richard Allen; the walkout from St. George's.

AME ZION · 1821

New York. James Varick; "the Freedom Church."

CME · 1870

Jackson, Tennessee. Formerly enslaved people governing their own church. **Our family.**

UMC · 1968

Dallas. Ended the segregated Central Jurisdiction.

Racism split the Methodist family. Black Methodists answered by building. Tonight: what all of them still believe, and how they live it.

PART 3

WHAT METHODISTS BELIEVE

Grace for all, all of life

1739 · “FREE GRACE”

GRACE FOR EVERYONE

Some preachers in Wesley’s day, including his friend George Whitefield, taught that God had chosen only some people to be saved.

Wesley disagreed. Christ died for everyone, and grace makes it possible for anyone to respond.

> *“The grace or love of God… is free in all, and free for all.”*
>
> **JOHN WESLEY, “FREE GRACE,” 1739**

“For the grace of God has appeared that offers salvation to all people.” Titus 2:11 (NIV)

WESLEY'S WAY OF SALVATION

THREE KINDS OF GRACE

PREVENIENT

Grace that **goes before.** God's love reaches us before we know God.

"We love because he first loved us."

1 John 4:19

JUSTIFYING

Grace that **pardons.** Forgiveness, received by faith, as a gift.

"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith."

Ephesians 2:8

SANCTIFYING

Grace that **transforms.** The Spirit growing us toward perfect love.

"If anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come."

2 Corinthians 5:17

PREVENIENT GRACE

GOD MOVES FIRST

BEFORE WE LOOK

God is already at work in every person: the conscience that nudges, the hunger for something more, the friend who invited you.

FREEDOM TO ANSWER

Wesley taught that on our own we can't turn to God. Prevenient grace frees us to say yes, or no.

NO ONE OUTSIDE

There is no one God's grace hasn't reached first. That changes how we see every neighbor.

"No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws them." John 6:44 (NIV)

JUSTIFYING GRACE

PARDONED, REBORN, ASSURED

JUSTIFIED

What God does **for** us: forgives our sins and restores the relationship.

BORN AGAIN

What God does **in** us: new life begins. Wesley called it the new birth.

ASSURED

We can know we belong to God. At Aldersgate, “an assurance was given me.”

“The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are God’s children.” Romans 8:16 (NIV)

SANCTIFYING GRACE

GOING ON TO PERFECTION

Wesley called the goal **Christian perfection**. It doesn't mean never making a mistake. It means a heart so full of love for God and neighbor that love rules it.

"Love the Lord your God with all your heart… Love your neighbor as yourself." *Matthew 22:37–39 (NIV)*

ASKED OF METHODIST PREACHERS SINCE WESLEY

"Are you going on to perfection?"

"Do you expect to be made perfect in love in this life?"

WESLEY'S PICTURE

THE PORCH, THE DOOR, THE HOUSE

THE PORCH

PREVENIENT GRACE

Repentance. Grace meets us outside and turns us toward home.

THE DOOR

JUSTIFYING GRACE

Faith. We walk in, forgiven and welcomed.

THE HOUSE

SANCTIFYING GRACE

Holiness. A whole life of growing in love, room by room.

From Wesley's *Principles of a Methodist Farther Explained* (1746).

B

QUESTION B

PART 3 · TALK ABOUT IT · ★ CORE

Which do you most need right now: grace that finds you (prevenient), grace that forgives you (justifying), or grace that grows you (sanctifying)?

C

QUESTION C

PART 3 · TALK ABOUT IT · OPTIONAL

Looking back, where can you see that God’s grace went before you, before you knew to look for it?

> *“Before I formed you in the womb I knew you.”*
> **Jeremiah 1:5 (NIV)**

PART 4

HOW METHODISTS LIVE

Rules, habits and a way of thinking

THE GENERAL RULES · 1743

THREE SIMPLE RULES

1 · DO NO HARM

"Hate what is evil; cling to what is good."

Romans 12:9

2 · DO GOOD

"Let us do good to all people."

Galatians 6:10 · Micah 6:8

3 · STAY IN LOVE WITH GOD

"If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit."

John 15:5

Wesley's wording for rule 3: "attending upon all the ordinances of God." "Stay in love with God" is Bishop Rueben Job's summary (2007).

1746 · “THE MEANS OF GRACE”

PUT YOURSELF IN GRACE’S WAY

WORKS OF PIETY

LOVING GOD

- Prayer
- Searching the Scriptures
- Holy Communion
- Fasting
- Holy conversation

WORKS OF MERCY

LOVING NEIGHBOR

- Feeding the hungry
- Visiting the sick and those in prison
- Caring for the poor
- Doing all the good you can

These habits don’t earn grace. They are the ordinary places where God has promised to meet us.

1742 · BRISTOL

THE CLASS MEETING

Every early Methodist belonged to a **class**: about a dozen people who met each week with a class leader.

It started as a way to collect a penny a week. It became the heart of the movement: prayer, honesty and holding each other up.

THE ONE QUESTION

“HOW IS IT WITH YOUR SOUL?”

D

QUESTION D

PART 4 · TALK ABOUT IT · OPTIONAL

Who is your “class”? Who asks you, “How is it with your soul?” And whom do you ask?

> *“Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed.”*
>
> **James 5:16 (NIV)**

E

QUESTION E

PART 4 · TALK ABOUT IT · ★ CORE

Which of the three simple rules is hardest for you right now? What would practicing it look like this week?

> *“He has shown you, O mortal, what is good.”*
> **Micah 6:8 (NIV)**

A WAY OF THINKING

THE WESLEYAN QUADRILATERAL

1 · SCRIPTURE

The foundation.
Primary authority.

2 Timothy 3:16–17

2 · TRADITION

The church's wisdom through history.

2 Thessalonians 2:15

3 · REASON

"Come now, and let us reason together."

Isaiah 1:18 (KJV)

4 · EXPERIENCE

The Spirit's witness in our lives.

Romans 8:16

Named by 20th-century scholar Albert Outler to describe Wesley's method. Not four equal sides: Scripture comes first.

F

QUESTION F

PART 4 · TRY IT · ★ CORE

Try the Quadrilateral: should I forgive someone who hasn’t apologized?

> *“Lord, how many times shall I forgive…? Jesus answered, ‘I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.’”*
>
> **Matthew 18:21–22 (NIV)**

SCRIPTURE	TRADITION	REASON	EXPERIENCE
What does the Bible say?	What has the church taught?	What makes sense here?	What have you lived?

WRAP-UP

TONIGHT IN ONE SLIDE

1. Grace is free for all. It goes before us, pardons us and transforms us.
2. Christian perfection means love ruling the heart, not never making a mistake.
3. Do no harm. Do good. Stay in love with God.
4. We put ourselves in grace's way with works of piety and works of mercy, together.
5. Scripture first, with tradition, reason and experience.

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE

PUT YOURSELF IN GRACE'S WAY

A WORK OF PIETY

One daily practice: 10 minutes of prayer, or a psalm a day.

A WORK OF MERCY

One person to help, by name, before next Wednesday.

ASK THE QUESTION

Ask one person, "How is it with your soul?" Then really listen.

Write all three on your handout, check off each day, and bring your story next week.

CLOSING PRAYER

God of free grace, you found us before we knew your name, you forgive us when we come home, and you are not finished with us yet. Keep us going on to perfection. Teach us to do no harm, to do good, and to stay in love with you, until your love rules our hearts. In Jesus' name, Amen.

NEXT WEDNESDAY

7:00 PM ET ON ZOOM

ID 880 2297 9559
Passcode 19061906
Handout: gracecommunityphilly.org